

Editorial

BlackBerry vs. The iPhone: Take a call

Maybe we can compare Apple's iPhone and RIM's BlackBerry. But to answer the question of which will win is like asking who will win in a fight between Superman and Spiderman.

To start with, the iPhone is not a phone — it is a computer that runs a 400 Mhz processor with 64 or 128 MB of RAM and a 6-12 GB of hard drive — as good as a Mac machine just about a few years back. The new iPhone 2.0 has improved dramatically over version 1—remote wipe, push email, faster browsing on the EDGE network, automatic calendar and contact synching—encompassing all those features that were missed by iPhone corporate users. And of course in the US, it is half the price at twice the speed of the BlackBerry.

The real question is, will it eat away the BlackBerry's market? You know, I think there could be a chance.

No, not because of the price advantage. In fact the price advantage in the US is due to the fact that AT&T has subsidised it to the \$200 mark. Think about it, a \$200 phone and an iPod thrown in, what a bargain! Yes, you are tied down to AT&T in a two-year contract. In India it will be much higher. Unless the likes of Airtel or Vodafone marry Apple.

If Steve Jobs is to be believed, the new version has even taken care of the security issues. The new iPhone has implemented security policy enforcement, certificate and identities with WPA2/802.1x protocols. It enables access to corporate networks of companies also through IPSec VPNs specially with push mail integrated with MS Exchange. The remote wipe is another interesting feature. Even if you lose your iPhone, you can wipe out all data from it remotely.

So what's happening at the stables of RIM? They seem pretty cool with the hype surrounding the iPhone. They are of the mentality that typing on glass (the iPhone is only touch screen, unless you have a pocket big enough to carry around a portable keyboard) is not a viable option. I think it is only a 'getting-used-to' problem. When people get used to it, there will be more adoption for the ergonomically designed iPhone. So till then you will see RIM touting the physical keyboard as the competitive advantage of the 'crackberry', as a



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friend of mine calls it. But if you listen harder you can still hear the second part saying—till people get used to typing on glass.

Now another reason I am saying that there is stiff competition to RIM is that what they tout has all been proven wrong. The iPhone now comes with advanced security features that will appease the IT managers of corporations who want to put it in the hands of their workers, it has push mail and most importantly, it is stronger in areas that BlackBerry is weak—music and video.

Now it's left to the consumer... More user-friendly, better battery life, and application availability and portability will be the deciding factors.

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